Project Report: IDP Girls Baking Training & Startup Kits

Reference: ADA/2022/005 **Period:** July 1–31, 2022 **Location:** Buea, South-West Region, Cameroon
Prepared by: Apoti Development Association (ADA)

Executive Summary

In July 2022, ADA successfully implemented its first vocational training program — a 4-week baking and pastry-making course for 15 internally displaced young girls in Buea. All 15 participants completed the training, received startup kits, and were equipped with both practical skills and business knowledge to launch small food enterprises. This project marked ADA's strategic shift from relief-based interventions to sustainable empowerment programming.

1. Background

Since 2016, the Anglophone crisis has forced hundreds of thousands from their homes in Cameroon's North-West and South-West regions. Many young girls arrived in Buea with no education, no skills, and no means of supporting themselves. They depended entirely on handouts and the goodwill of host communities.

ADA recognized that while immediate relief addresses survival, it does not build futures. The IDP Girls Baking Training was conceived as a pilot vocational program — proof that with modest investment, displaced young women could become economically independent.

2. Project Implementation

Participant Selection

ADA volunteers identified candidates through community outreach in IDP-concentrated neighborhoods in Buea. From 28 applicants, 15 were selected based on:

- Confirmed displacement from NW/SW regions
- Lack of existing vocational skills or employment
- Demonstrated motivation and commitment
- Vulnerability level (no family support, no income)

Training Delivery

Instructor: A professional baker with 8 years of commercial experience was engaged to lead all sessions.

Schedule: Monday–Friday, 8:00 AM – 2:00 PM, for 4 consecutive weeks.

Curriculum covered:

- **Week 1:** Bread baking fundamentals — white bread, milk bread, coconut bread
- **Week 2:** Pastries and snacks — meat pies, sausage rolls, doughnuts, cakes, chin-chin, puff-puff
- **Week 3:** Commercial production — scaling recipes, quality control, packaging, preservation
- **Week 4:** Business skills — costing, pricing, customer service, record-keeping, business planning

Volunteer Support

Six ADA volunteers rotated daily to provide:

- Transport coordination (ensuring all girls arrived safely)

- Materials preparation and kitchen setup
- Mentoring and encouragement
- Photography and documentation
- Attendance tracking

Graduation and Kit Distribution

On July 29, 2022, a graduation ceremony was held. Each of the 15 graduates received:

- Certificate of completion
- Startup kit containing:
  - 5-litre Mayor cooking oil
  - Large plastic bucket (mixing/storage)
  - Baking tray and measuring tools
  - Initial supply of flour, sugar, eggs, butter, and yeast

3. Participant Stories

Blessing, 19 — From Bamenda

"I left Bamenda when soldiers burned our house. I came to Buea with nothing. For two years I was just sitting, depending on people. Now I wake up at 4 AM to bake bread. I sell at the junction near Mile 17. Some days I make 3,000 CFA profit. It's not much, but it's mine."

Blessing specializes in milk bread and coconut bread. Within two weeks of graduation, she established a daily bread route, selling to regular customers at a busy junction. She reinvested her first profits into buying larger quantities of flour.

Grace, 17 — From Kumba

"I never thought I could do something like this. In my village I was still in school. When we ran, school stopped. This training gave me something better than sitting and crying."

Grace partnered with another graduate to sell doughnuts and puff-puff at the Buea Town market. They split costs and take turns at the selling point. By August, they were producing 200 doughnuts per market day.

Comfort, 22 — From Mamfe

"The business part was what changed everything for me. I knew how to cook before, but I didn't know how to price things or keep records. Now I write everything down. I know exactly what I spend and what I earn."

Comfort focused on meat pies and sausage rolls, selling to offices and schools in the Molyko area. She developed a pre-order system, taking orders the day before and delivering fresh in the morning.

Patience, 20 — From Bali

"My startup kit was like gold to me. The oil, the bucket, the ingredients — I started baking the very next day after graduation. I didn't waste even one day."

Patience began with chin-chin and puff-puff sold at her neighborhood junction. Within a month, she added cakes for weekend orders and began taking birthday cake commissions.

Divine, 18 — From Wum

"Before this program, I was ashamed. I felt useless. Now when people ask what I do, I say I'm a baker. I have a skill. I have dignity."

Divine sells bread and pastries from a small table outside her rented room. She serves the immediate neighborhood and has built a loyal customer base through consistent quality.

4. Outcomes and Impact

Quantitative Results

Indicator	Target	Achieved
Girls enrolled	15	15
Girls completing training	15	15 (100%)
Startup kits distributed	15	15
Business plans developed	15	15
Girls launching businesses (within 1 month)	10	12

Qualitative Outcomes

- **Skills acquisition:** All 15 participants demonstrated competency in bread baking, pastry production, and at least 3 product types
- **Economic empowerment:** 12 of 15 graduates launched income-generating activities within one month of graduation
- **Confidence and dignity:** Participants reported significant improvement in self-worth and sense of purpose
- **Peer networks:** Girls formed informal support groups, sharing tips, bulk-buying ingredients together, and covering each other's selling points
- **Community recognition:** Host community members expressed appreciation for the program, noting reduced dependency

Strategic Significance

This project was ADA's first vocational training initiative. It proved that:

1. Modest budgets ($1,500) can create lasting impact when invested in skills
2. IDP girls are eager and capable learners when given opportunity
3. The relief-to-empowerment model works and is replicable
4. Startup kits remove the barrier between training and action

5. Challenges and Lessons Learned

Challenges

Challenge	How Addressed
Some girls had never used an oven	Extra practice time, peer tutoring
Language barriers (Francophone girls)	Bilingual volunteer support
Childcare needs (2 participants had infants)	Volunteers assisted with childcare during sessions

Ingredient costs rose mid-project	Adjusted quantities slightly, used contingency

Lessons Learned

1. **Start with what sells locally** — Bread and doughnuts have immediate market demand in Buea; complex pastries can come later
2. **Business skills are as important as baking skills** — Participants who grasped pricing and record-keeping launched faster
3. **Startup kits are essential** — Without materials, training alone doesn't translate to action
4. **Peer support accelerates success** — Girls who partnered or formed groups performed better
5. **Follow-up matters** — Monthly check-ins after graduation helped sustain momentum

6. Sustainability

- Graduates continue operating independently using skills acquired
- Peer networks provide ongoing mutual support
- Some graduates are training family members, multiplying impact
- ADA plans to use this model for future vocational programs
- Low cost per beneficiary ($100/girl) makes replication feasible

7. Recommendations

1. **Expand to 25–30 participants** in future cohorts
2. **Add 1-month mentorship period** after graduation for business coaching
3. **Create alumni network** connecting graduates across cohorts
4. **Explore partnerships** with local bakeries for apprenticeship placements
5. **Document recipes** in a simple booklet graduates can reference

8. Conclusion

The IDP Girls Baking Training proved that ADA can deliver effective vocational programming at minimal cost with maximum impact. Fifteen girls who arrived in Buea with nothing now have skills, materials, and the confidence to feed themselves and their families. This project established the template for ADA's future empowerment initiatives and demonstrated that the path from displacement to dignity can begin with flour, sugar, and determination.

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